



BEFORE THE FLINTLOCK

UP TO 1650

A gunlock, or firing mechanism, ignites propellant—gunpowder—to fire a projectile down the barrel of a gun. At first, firearms had no special mechanism for igniting the charge, just a smoldering hemp-cord to light the gunpowder. Then the development of gunlocks such as the matchlock and wheel-lock—and ultimately the flintlock—mechanisms made guns quicker and easier to fire.